

GARGANO — THE INLAND VILLAGES

Voice: Stefano, 58, park ranger with the Civil Protection of the Gargano

GARGANO — THE INLAND VILLAGES

Voice: Stefano, 58, park ranger with the Civil Protection of the Gargano

CAP. 1 — INTRO: THE GARGANO YOU DON'T SEE FROM THE SEA

The Gargano you know is the one by the sea.

Beaches, coves, trabucchi, tourists. It's beautiful, it's real, I won't deny it. But it's the façade.

Behind that façade are the villages. Clinging to the hillsides, with narrow streets winding around the rocky spur, churches at the center, old men sitting outside. Villages that existed centuries before anyone realized the sea here was beautiful.

My name is Stefano. Fifty-eight years old. Park ranger with the Gargano Civil Protection for thirty years. I've walked every trail on this promontory. I've watched entire forests burn. I've seen vegetation come back where it seemed impossible.

I'm going to tell you about the Gargano you can't reach with your GPS set to the sea. The one you find by looking up toward the hills.

CAP. 2 — VICO DEL GARGANO: THE VILLAGE OF CITRUS AND ALLEYWAYS

Vico del Gargano is considered one of the most beautiful villages in Italy.

It's not one of those made-up rankings. Anyone who visits understands why.

The medieval historic center is intact — alleyways so narrow two people barely pass each other, arches connecting houses overhead, stone steps that seem to go on forever. The village is built on rock, literally — some foundations are bare bedrock.

Surrounding the village, the citrus groves. Vico is famous for its late-ripening mandarins — a local variety that matures in February, when the rest of Italy has no more fresh citrus. In winter you can smell the village before you see it. Like Rodi, but different — denser, sweeter.

There's also the Foresta Umbra a few kilometers away. Vico is the gateway village for those entering the park from the north. In summer tourists rush through on their way to the sea. That's a mistake. Vico deserves a whole morning — getting lost in the alleyways, eating something at the bar in the center, buying mandarins if they're in season.

CAP. 3 — ISCHITELLA AND LAKE VARANO

Ischitella sits above Lake Varano.

Six hundred meters above sea level, the village looks down on the lake from above. It's a position you don't forget — from certain spots you can see the lake in front of you, the Adriatic Sea beyond, and the Gargano promontory stretching out toward the east. All of it at once, in a single glance.

Lake Varano is the largest coastal lake in Italy. Sixteen kilometers long, separated from the sea by a strip of sand. Like Lesina, but bigger and wilder. Less known, less visited, more authentic.

The eels from Varano are famous throughout Puglia. The lake has been producing them for centuries — the brackish waters create perfect conditions. The fishermen of Varano use techniques passed down from generation to generation, with wicker traps lowered into spots they know by heart.

Ischitella itself is a small village — fewer than two thousand inhabitants. But it has a square with a view worth the trip. Elderly men sit outside in the evenings and watch the lake change color with the sunset. They've done it all their lives. They don't think it's extraordinary. It is.

Let me tell you something you won't find in any travel guide.

On State Road 693 dei Laghi, near Cagnano Varano, there's a service station. The Station Petrolgas. Around kilometer 32. Fifteen minutes from Rodi.

Stop there.

Not for the petrol. For the bar. There's a raised terrace overlooking the lake — a view across all of Varano, and on clear days you can see the Diomedee on the horizon. The Tremiti, as they're called today.

It's the most scenic service station I know. The locals know it. People stop for a coffee, look at the lake, and drive on. One of those places that don't appear on maps but live in the memory of those who belong here.

CAP. 4 — THE EUCALYPTUS GROVE: A STORY FEW KNOW

If you drive along the coast between Foce Varano and Capoiale, at some point you'll see a forest unlike anything else.

Tall trees, with bark that peels in pale strips, long leaves that smell of menthol. They're not native trees. They're eucalyptus. By the sea, right on the edge of the coast, a distinctive grove you don't expect to find. And their story on this promontory is a story of mistakes and remedies.

In the 1950s and 60s, the Italian State launched a reforestation program for the Gargano. The original forests had been decimated over the centuries — felled for timber, burned to make way for pasture. The vegetation cover needed to be rebuilt.

Eucalyptus was chosen. It grows fast, adapts to poor soils, withstands drought. It seemed like the perfect solution.

The problem is that eucalyptus is not a Mediterranean tree. It doesn't create ecosystems — very few animal species use it, the soil beneath it is nearly sterile, it doesn't retain water like native oaks do.

That grove between Foce Varano and Capoiale has become something of its own, though — a recognizable landscape, distinctive, that the locals know and spot from a distance. Today the Gargano National Park is working to gradually reintroduce native species. It's a long process — decades. But it's moving in the right direction.

CAP. 5 — THE FIRE: JULY 24, 2007

There's a date that no one who works on this promontory ever forgets.

July 24, 2007.

It was a Tuesday. The wind was blowing hard from the west. It was the height of July — the Gargano was full of tourists, the campsites packed, the beaches crowded.

That day a fire devastated Peschici.

It wasn't a fire far off in the woods. It was a fire that reached the village itself, the campsites, the houses. Gas cylinders exploded. The smoke was visible for tens of kilometers. Three hundred injured among tourists and residents. Hectares of scrubland destroyed.

Three people died.

Domenico De Nittis, sixty-two years old, a merchant. Carmela Fasanella, eighty-one years old. Romano Fasanella, seventy-one years old. The Fasanella siblings were found burned in their car.

Many people fled into the water. Local fishermen went out with their boats to rescue them. Emergency services worked through the night.

I was on duty that day. Fifteen hours in the field. When you come home after something like that, you can't sleep. You close your eyes and you still see the fire.

CAP. 6 — AFTER THE FIRE: WHAT REMAINS AND WHAT RETURNS

Fire does a strange thing to a landscape.

It burns everything — the scrub, the trees, the nests, the burrows. It leaves behind black ground, bare, that looks dead forever.

It's not dead forever.

Three weeks after the blaze, if it rains, the first grasses begin to appear. After a year the first shrubs are already there. After five years the low forest is back. After twenty years you can barely see any trace of it.

That's why a park ranger's work after a fire doesn't end with the extinguishing. It begins with the extinguishing. You have to manage the recovery — planting oaks and holm oaks, protecting the seedlings from wild boar. It's years of work. Silent. Nobody sees it.

But when I go back into the forests burned in 2007 and find oaks two meters tall where there was ash, I understand why I do it.

CAP. 7 — ARSONISTS: THE TRUTH NOBODY WANTS TO SAY

I need to tell you something people don't like to say out loud.

Most of the fires on the Gargano are not accidental.

It's not a spark. It's not a cigarette butt. It's not the heat. It's hands. People who set fires deliberately.

The reasons vary. Property speculation — a burned forest can more easily become buildable land. Family rivalries. Economic interests I don't understand and don't want to.

The Archbishop of Manfredonia, after the 2024 fire at Vieste, said something I agree with word for word: these fires are criminal acts committed against the humanity of today and tomorrow. I couldn't put it better.

We park rangers know. We know from the way they start, from where they ignite, from multiple outbreaks happening at the same time. A forest doesn't catch fire in three different spots at the exact same moment by accident.

This is the heaviest part of the job. Not the fire itself. Knowing that someone set it.

CAP. 8 — VARANO: THE LAKE IN WINTER

In summer Lake Varano is almost ignored by tourists.

Everyone goes to the sea. The lake sits there, still, quiet, with fishermen heading out at dawn and returning by mid-morning.

In winter the lake becomes extraordinary.

Migratory birds stop here. Herons, cormorants, wild ducks, spoonbills. At certain times of year you see flamingos — not as many as at the Saline di Margherita di Savoia, but they're there. Pink, motionless in the shallow water, their thin legs looking barely strong enough to hold them.

The lake in November, with low mist over the water and reeds bending in the wind, is one of the most beautiful landscapes I know. It's not the Gargano of postcards. It's the real Gargano. The one that exists when the tourists have gone.

CAP. 9 — WHAT TO DO: THE INLAND VILLAGES

First: don't stop at the sea alone.

Give at least half a day to the villages. Vico del Gargano is twenty minutes from the coast. Ischitella is half an hour. From Peschici you're up there in ten minutes. It's not a demanding excursion — it's a road.

For Vico: go early in the morning or in the late afternoon. At noon in summer the center is hot and crowded. In the evening, though, the village comes alive — people come out, bars open their tables outside, you eat well for very little.

For Lake Varano: go by bike or on foot along the embankment. There are marked trails that follow the lake for kilometers. It's flat, shaded, and you'll barely meet anyone.

For the forests: stay on marked trails. Don't light fires. Ever. Not even a barbecue. Not even a cigarette. In summer the risk is real and the damage lasts twenty years.

CAP. 10 — THE PARK'S ANIMALS: THE ONES THAT CAME BACK

In the Gargano National Park there are animals that weren't here twenty years ago.

The wolf has returned.

There had been no wolves in Puglia for centuries. Then, slowly, they started coming down from the Apennine ridge toward the south. Now they're here. Not many — a few

packs, a few solitary individuals. I see them on camera traps. I almost never see them in person.

There are fallow deer — the Gargano fallow deer, a native subspecies, darker than the continental one. Wild boar, numerous, and far less shy than you'd expect. The black woodpecker in the beech forests. The rock partridge on the high ledges.

The park is not a zoo. These animals don't appear on demand. You see them if you're patient, if you stay still, if you go at the right hours — dawn and dusk. Or if you work here, as I do, and learn to read the signs.

CAP. 11 — THE TRAILS: HOW YOU WALK HERE

The Gargano National Park has a network of trails.

Not all of them are marked the same way. Some are excellent — well maintained, easy to follow. Others are tracks that only locals know well. My advice: get a paper map, don't rely on GPS alone. In some forests the signal doesn't reach.

The routes around Vico del Gargano and Ischitella are among the finest. You walk through olive groves and citrus orchards, with views of Lake Varano on one side and the sea on the other. In spring the citrus blossom scents the whole valley.

For the trails in the Foresta Umbra — the one between Vieste and Monte Sant'Angelo — you need proper trekking boots. The ground is roots and earth. After rain it gets slippery. In summer the forest is cool — even with thirty degrees outside, inside you're comfortable.

CAP. 12 — CARPINO AND FOLK MUSIC

There's a village near here called Carpino.

Most tourists don't know it. A thousand inhabitants, perched on the hillside, looking out over Lake Varano. From the outside it looks like any other Gargano village.

But Carpino has a musical tradition centuries old. The tammurriata, the battente guitar, the fishermen's chants from the lake. A music that smells of sea and mountain at the same time, like the place where it was born.

Every year in August the Carpino Folk Music Festival takes place. Musicians from all over Puglia, from Italy, sometimes from abroad. It's not a tourist festival — it's the real thing, put on by people who study and live this music.

I've been four times. At night, in the historic center, with music bouncing off the stones — it's one of those experiences you won't find in any travel guide. And yet here it is, twenty

minutes down the road.

CAP. 13 — THE PARK RANGER'S WORK: A TYPICAL DAY

Nobody really knows what I do.

People think: he walks around in the woods, watches animals, good life.

Part of that's true. The beautiful part is true. But there's the rest too.

Morning: checking the trails, inspecting the signs, assessing damage caused by wild boar. The boar break through the fences around olive groves — every week there's some angry farmer. He's right to be angry. But I'm right too when I say you can't cull a boar without authorization.

Then the camera traps — going out to check them, downloading the images, logging the sightings. Then the tourists — those who go off-trail, who pick mushrooms without a permit, who light fires where they shouldn't. The part of the job I don't enjoy. But it has to be done.

At the end of the day, when everything's settled, I sit on a rock above the lake. I watch the water. I wait. Sometimes a fallow deer comes down to drink. Those five minutes make up for everything else.

CAP. 14 — FIRE AND EARTH: WHAT GROWS AFTER A BLAZE

People often ask me: after a fire, how long before the forest comes back?

The answer depends on the fire.

A fast fire, one that moves across the surface — the roots survive. They sprout again in spring. In three years the forest is recognizable again.

A deep fire, one that scorches the earth — that's different. The one in 2007 at Peschici was deep. The soil burned. The roots burned. What grew back afterward is different from what was there before.

Now, almost twenty years later, in some areas the Mediterranean scrub has re-established itself — lentisk, rosemary, rock rose. But the old pines, the ones that had been there for decades, are gone. It takes a century to make a forest. To destroy it, five hours are enough.

CAP. 15 — LAKE VARANO: THE STORY OF AN ENCLOSED WATER

Lake Varano was not always a lake.

Or rather — it was always water, but not always the same water. Long ago it was a bay open to the sea. Then the sediments of the Candelaro and other streams built up the sandbar that separates it from the Adriatic. Millennia of accumulation, grain by grain. The bay became a lagoon, the lagoon became a lake.

Today the only connection with the sea is through the inlets to the east. The water is brackish — neither fully fresh nor fully salty. Perfect for certain fish species. Perfect for eels. Perfect for birds seeking a transitional environment.

In winter there are flamingos here too — a few, not like at Margherita. But I see them. I see them from the embankment, with binoculars, in the low light of January. Every time it catches me off guard.

CAP. 16 — THE VILLAGES: WHY THEY'RE STILL INHABITED

A question I'm asked often: how come these villages haven't emptied out?

Partly they have. Vico del Gargano had more inhabitants thirty years ago. So did Ischitella. Young people leave for Foggia, for Bari, out of Puglia altogether. It's no secret.

But they hold on. They don't disappear. Because there are still families tied to the land — to the olive groves, to the citrus orchards. Because slow tourism is reaching here too — those who seek the Gargano beyond the beach, who want the villages, who rent a house for a week and want the quiet.

My work as a park ranger brings people here who wouldn't come without the park. Guided hikes, wildlife watching, guided trekking. Not huge numbers. But people who sleep in the villages, eat in the villages, spend in the villages. A drop. But drops count.

CAP. 17 — TIME HERE: SLOW AND SEASONAL

Time here has a rhythm the city has forgotten.

In spring you prune, plant the vegetable gardens, prepare the equipment. In summer you harvest the first vegetables, endure the heat, take a holiday if you're lucky. In autumn you pick the olives, the tomatoes, prepare for winter. In winter you fix what broke, stay close to home, wait for spring.

It's an old clock. It doesn't work for everyone — it takes a certain capacity to be still, to wait. But for those who have it, this rhythm is a form of sanity.

I work inside it every day — the park follows the seasons, the animals follow the seasons. I can't force anything. I have to wait. And in that patience I've learned more than I've

learned any other way.

CAP. 18 — CLOSING: STEFANO SAYS GOODBYE

Thirty years on this promontory.

I've watched forests burn that my father had taken me to see as a child. I've seen trees come back where I thought it was impossible. I've seen villages empty in winter and fill up in summer. I've seen tourists arrive in ever greater numbers — the Germans, the Dutch, and now the Americans too.

The Gargano holds up under all of this because it's large. Large and varied. It's not just beaches — it's forests, lakes, villages, hills, history. Those who see it only from the sea see one tenth of it.

I ask just one thing. When you're here, treat this place as if it belongs to someone. Because it does. It belongs to me, to my son, to the children of the fishermen and rangers who work here all year long.

Take it with you in your memories. But leave it intact.

This promontory has other faces.

The sea at Vieste, the islands on the horizon you saw from the lake, the bell towers of Monte Sant'Angelo, the trabucchi coast at sunset. Each one has someone who tells it. Someone who was born there, who worked there, who never left.

The Gargano doesn't end here.